

U.S. attorney faces complaints of partisanship

Essayli has strong backing of Trump officials, but critics ramp up opposition.

By Kevin Rector, Brittney Mejia and James Queally

When Bill Essayli was appointed interim U.S. attorney for the Los Angeles region in April, many in the former state assemblyman's Riverside County district were afraid the ambitious Republican lightning rod would be willing to attack a whole range of California policies to please the MAGA base.

They feared that, as the region's most powerful fed-

eral prosecutor, Essayli would bow to the Trump administration and ramp up assaults on queer people, immigrants, voting rights, environmental protections and anyone or anything else that displeased President Trump.

Now, it's clear they were right to worry, said Jacob Daruvala, an LGBTQ+ advocate from the Inland Empire.

"Essayli is a very specific and terrible threat," Daruvala said during a recent town hall for the "Stop Essayli" campaign, which is working to block the top prosecutor's permanent appointment. "He has already shown multiple times that he is willing to use the office in a partisan manner."

Nearly four months into [See Essayli, A6]



Syrian city is victim of mass killings

Sectarian violence has transformed a well-appointed city into a slaughterhouse.

By Nabih Bulos

SWEIDA, Syria — The last thing Hatem Radhwan heard the fighters say was, "Kill them all. We don't want them identifying us."

That's when the five gunmen, clad in desert camouflage uniforms and who claimed they were with Syria's Ministry of Defense, cocked their AK-47 rifles, shouted, "You pigs!" and sprayed the room with bullets.

Radhwan, a 70-year-old blacksmith, felt a bullet or a piece of debris — he couldn't tell — graze his upper lip. He fell to the ground as the gunmen continued to fire.

Rashad Abu Saadeh, a neighbor who hid in his apartment across the street, heard the gunfire. "For more than half a minute they kept shooting," he said. "It felt like a long, long time."

The killings at the Radhwan family salon were part of a paroxysm of sectarian violence that engulfed the Druze-majority city of Sweida last week. The fighting, which involved tank and mortar bombardment, summary executions and Israeli airstrikes, left some 1,380 dead, displaced more than 120,000 others — and turned what once was a well-appointed city, largely spared the ravages of Syria's 14-year civil war, into a slaughterhouse.

"There isn't a single home in the whole province that isn't grieving someone," said Randa Mihrez, one of [See Syria, A4]



DRUZE factions, top, move displaced families to mountains. Center, Druze fighter at the National Hospital. Above, one of the many injured receives treatment.

A front-row seat to future wealth?

Even with the box office down, investors see the potential in buying movie studios.

By Samantha Masunaga

The theatrical box office market is down. It's harder than ever to get people out of their homes and into the cinema. The business model for movies in streaming is still a work in progress.

Given all these challenges, who would want to buy a movie studio now?

Many people, it turns out. Earlier this month, the entertainment industry was abuzz after reports that film and TV production company Legendary Entertainment,

the company behind "Dune" and "A Minecraft Movie," was mulling a potential acquisition of "The Hunger Games" and "John Wick" producer and distributor Lionsgate Studios. Both companies have declined to comment on the reports.

It's hardly the only deal news in the film business.

In June, independent film finance and production firm Alcon Media Group — known for "The Blind Side" and "Blade Runner 2049" — bought the film library of "Joker" and "Ocean's Eleven" producer and financier Village Roadshow Entertainment for \$417.5 million after an auction process that was part of the West Hollywood company's Chapter 11 [See Studios, A12]

ICE raids cloud picture for legal pot

Aftermath is devastating for one of state's largest cannabis operators



A HOTHOUSE glows at a cannabis farm on California's Central Coast. Recent ICE raids at Glass House Brands have left the industry shaken.

By Jessica Garrison and Melissa Gomez

Ever since federal immigration agents raided one of the largest licensed cannabis operators in the state this month, the phones of cannabis industry insiders have been blazing with messages of fear, sadness and confusion.

"It sent shock waves through the community," said Hirsh Jain, the founder of Ananda Strategy, which advises cannabis businesses. "Everyone is on text threads."

Glass House Brands, whose cannabis operations have helped make Santa Barbara and Ventura counties the new cannabis capitals of California, has long been among the most prominent companies in the state's wild frontier of legal cannabis. Some call it the "Walmart of Weed" for its streamlined, low-cost production methods, its gargantuan market share and its phalanx of [See Cannabis, A8]

Months after Eaton fire, remains found

Officials confirm what is hoped to be the final death from the January conflagration.

By Grace Toohey

While Katherine Alcantara was evacuating from her smoke-filled west Altadena home during January's firestorm, she remembered seeing her longtime neighbor returning home across the street.

In the chaos, she assumed he had come back to rescue his pets and grab some important belongings before heading to safety.

She never imagined he wouldn't make it out.

"I remember hearing the dogs barking hysterically. ... Did he try to save the house? Did he pass out?" Alcantara, 45, recalled this week in an interview with The Times. "I can't believe they found the body now, like six months later."

Officials this week confirmed the presence of human remains in the only un-

cleared lot on La Venezia Court, a small residential block where neighbors said 74-year-old Juan Francisco Espinoza had lived alone with his dogs. The confirmation of another fatality brings the Eaton fire death toll to 19 and the overall death toll from the Jan. 7 firestorm, including the Palisades fire, to 31. All but one of the Eaton fire deaths occurred in west Altadena, where evacuation orders for residents came hours after the fire had already arrived, according to a Times investigation.

The neighborhood where Espinoza lived received the most delayed evacuation orders, with electronic alerts going out to his section of west Altadena just before 6 a.m. on Jan. 8 — almost 12 hours after the fire started. About a mile to the east, where the community is generally more affluent and less diverse, electronic evacuation orders were sent out about an hour after the fire broke out just after 6 p.m. Jan. 7, according to records of archived alerts. [See Victim, A9]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times ROSALIA ESPINO, who lost her Altadena home in the Eaton fire, helped create a fire victims memorial.

Billions in withheld school grants set for release

By Howard Blume

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration is releasing billions of dollars in grants to schools for adult literacy, English language instruction and other pro-

grams, including at least \$800 million for California.

On July 1, the administration withheld the education funds — already appropriated by Congress — as it conducted a "programmatic review" about how the money was being spent and

whether it complied with President Trump's priorities, policies and executive orders. The actions disrupted school districts throughout the country — including in Republican-led states — that were depending on the release of the

funds.

The funding freeze had been challenged by at least two major lawsuits, including one from California and other states in which Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta played a key role in filing. [See Education fund, A14]

What's next for Paramount deal?

Questions of creative freedom, TV's future and other issues loom as Skydance merger nears finish line. **BUSINESS, A10**

Wrong turn spurs deportation case

Federal government signals no leniency for man living in the U.S. under Obama-era program. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

UCLA's new QB plays defense

Nico Iamaleava fields questions about transfer from Tennessee, saying he wanted to be near family. **SPORTS, B12**

Weather
Turning sunny.
L.A. Basin: 78/60. **B8**

